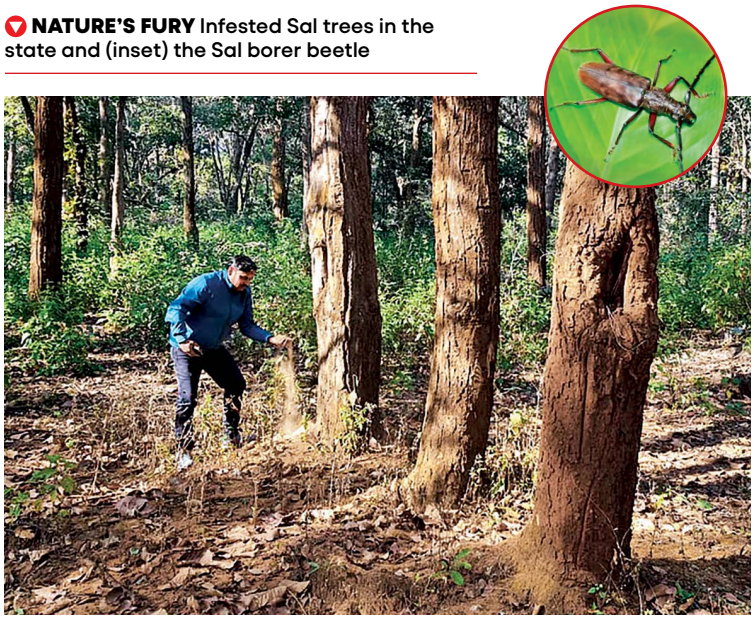
sought permission to fell 150,000 trees to limit the damage.

To be sure, the Sal borer lives alongside the Sal and affects 2-3 per cent of trees in a given area at any time. But experts say it sees a surge in population every three decades or so. On such occasions, it leaves a trail of destruction—impacting the local ecology, the defoliation spiking temperatures, and also threatening the value of timber. The last major infestation here, in the late 1990s, had spread to the neighbouring districts of Mandla, Umaria and Shahdol, later affecting trees in distant Narmadapuram district too. So when the first signs of an upcoming episode came in December 2025, forest officials lost no time in making an inventory of affected trees and rolling out their emergency SOP.

NATURE'S FURY Infested Sal trees in the state and (inset) the Sal borer beetle



THE BABY EATS THE TREE

How does this beetle ruin the tree? The female beetle lays eggs in the monsoon. The larva, white in colour, bores holes through the bark while feeding on the sapwood. Through this tunnel-like creation, it finally reaches the heartwood. The adult beetle is black and has antennae. That is its normal life-cycle. But in years when the beetle sees a demographic surge, the trees across entire forests bear bullet hole-like perforations. The timber falls 30-40 per cent in value—from Rs 40,000 per cubic metre.

Locals are being paid Rs 2 per beetle—captured and turned in. Around 1.4 million beetles, worth some Rs 30 lakh in bounty, are in. The department's traditional method of capture is 'trap tree'. Affected or even healthy Sal trees are cut into logs, and their sap extracted via incisions. The sap attracts the beetle, often from over a mile away. Imagine no heaven for the gathered beetles.

Researchers are working on newer measures, says Subharanjan Sen, principal chief conservator of forests, MP. The affected trees have been slotted from Grade 1 to 8. Grade 1-6 will be felled in November, says Mastram Baghel, chief conservator of forests, Jabalpur. The rest rejuvenate. ■

By **Rohit Parihar**

ON A 180-KILOMETRE RUN OF NH-48, through Jaipur Rural and the Kotputli-Behror stretch that marks the half-way halt before Delhi, a simple protocol is saving lives. For a year, what the Rajasthan Police enforced was nothing spectacular, just basic traffic hygiene: stay in your lane, no dangerous overtaking, and get forewarned before entering accident-prone stretches. The results are striking. Between September 2024 and August 2025, before this 'Driving 101' rulebook came into play, the stretch had recorded 435 accidents, with 258 deaths and 448 on the injured list. After enforcement, from September 2025 to August 2026, the same dashboard read: 337, 203, 288. That is, almost a hundred crashes reduced, with 55 fewer deaths.

The data is not conclusive proof that lane discipline was the sole cause, but it would be foolish to ignore it as a road sign. The system is uncomplicated. Heavy vehicles—trucks, trailers, buses—use the left-most lane, with the middle lane for overtaking. Cars and light vehicles have a separate lane; the right-most lane is also for emergency vehicles. The initiative, launched in August 2025 on a 125-km stretch, was extended within a month by another 55 km. Jaipur Range Inspector General Rahul Prakash is at the wheel; the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) came in to reinforce lane markings, close unauthorised cuts in medians, clear vegetation, instal signs.

A WAR ON VIOLATIONS

Enforcement, similarly, is multi-modal. Signs, toll plaza announcements and direct communication with transport operators keep the public aware. Patrol squads and interceptors use the VoC mobile app to record incidents, upload photos, report congestion or breakdowns, log enforcement activity, and coordinate internally. The Integrated Traffic Management System (ITMS) collates data from CCTVs and traffic